Mehrdad Pourghasem

PhD Candidate in Economics, Pennsylvania State University

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Research Interests

Industrial Organization, Health Economics, and Applied Microeconomics

Education

PhD in Economics, Pennsylvania State University 2022–2028 (expected)
Committee: Conor Ryan (chair), Paul Grieco, Bradley Setzler, David Vanness

MSc in Economics, Sharif University of Technology 2019–2022

BSc in Industrial Engineering, Sharif University of Technology 2014–2019

Research

Who Chooses Your Hospital? Primary-Care Referrals and Hospital Merger Review. *Job Market Paper*

Hospital merger review relies on demand models in which patients choose among all nearby hospitals. In HMOs and other gatekeeper plans, however, patients reach a hospital through referrals that begin at their primary-care practice, and each practice sends its patients to a small set of hospitals. Linking 184 million claims from California's all-payer claims database (2018–2023) to federal provider registries, I identify each commercially insured patient's primary-care practice, specialists and surgeon, and reconstruct the sequence of care that leads to her hospital admission. I then re-estimate the willingness-to-pay model used in merger review, restricting each patient's choice set to the hospitals her practice routinely sends patients to. In gatekeeper plans, the referral-based model clears more than a quarter of the mergers the standard model flags. It also predicts that more than twice as many displaced patients stay within the same hospital system. In open-access plans, the two models predict nearly the same diversion.

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Pennsylvania State University Summer 2025
Course: Introduction to Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy (enrollment 38).

Teaching Assistant, Pennsylvania State University Fall 2022–Present
Courses: Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis; International Finance, Open Economy Macroeconomics; Advanced International Trade.

Teaching Assistant, Sharif University of Technology Fall 2017–Fall 2021
Courses: Energy Economics, Game Theory, Principles of Economics, System Dynamics.

Professional Experience

Analyst, Morvarid Petrochemical Company Oct 2019–Dec 2020
- Visited the company's sites and worked with its managers to scope open-ended strategic questions into a defined project with a work plan and milestones.
- Built a quantitative model of how external conditions such as inflation and the exchange rate feed through to output and profitability, ran scenario analyses, and presented the results to the executive team.

Analyst, Iranian Water Policy Research Institute Oct 2017–Dec 2018
- Framed the client's needs as research questions for the project's first phase, reviewed the literature, and developed a conceptual model of regional water allocation.
- Ran the field interviews and wrote up the findings; presented them at a Chamber of Commerce forum attended by more than 100 farmers, officials, and business representatives.

Analyst, Urmia Lake Restoration Commission Jul 2017–Sep 2017
- Turned the project's analyses into policy reports and presentations for the commission.

Analyst, Smartup Ventures Jul 2016–Jul 2017
- Benchmarked contract terms across peer firms and prepared briefs for the CEO.

Computer Skills

Python, R, Stata, SQL, MATLAB, Julia, LaTeX, C, C++, ArcGIS, Tableau, Power BI, Excel.